Indian food history published three decades ago.

Much of the daunting task of condensing the insurmountable amount of information into one volume was taken on by the three eminent food writers and editors who brought this book to life. But the *Handbook* also draws on the expertise of other leading food writers, who bring their own unique expertise and voice to their subjects. The entry on 'Alcohol', for instance, is written by historian and researcher Prasun Chatterjee, who traces the evolution of the drinking culture in India from ancient to colonial times, with fascinating references from scriptures and mythologies. Journalist and food writer Hoihnu Hauzel's dominant voice on Northeastern cuisines is reflected in her entries on Meghalaya and Nagaland, while cultural researcher Priya Mani's entry on the unique vegetarian cuisine of the Palghat Iyers is based partly on oral interviews conducted by the author.

The *Handbook* is fairly easy to navigate; you can flit in and out as you please. The entries are detailed, with cross references and suggestions for further reading. The only dampener to this otherwise brilliant attempt are the poorly printed black and white illustrations accompanying some of the entries—they take away rather than add to the text. That said, this book is a must-have for any enthusiast or connoisseur of Indian cuisine. ■

Satarupa Paul

The late Raghavan Iyer, in his final book, set out to educate and guide readers through the complex history of the unique curries that can be found all over the globe. Iyer delves into cuisines across the continents through lore, anecdotes, interpretations and history, embracing the flavours of curry and highlighting 50 irresistible recipes. The acclaimed Indian cooking advocate leaves behind a rich legacy, and all Indian food enthusiasts must add this book to their Iyer collection.

by Sharmistha Chaudhuri

CELEBRATING INDIA

Australian chef Gary Mehigan is back on TV with National Geographic's *India's Mega Festivals*

Get set to see Australian chef, restaurateur, and TV personality Gary Mehigan as you've never seen him before. Whether he's donning a *mundu* to row in a Kerala boat race during Onam or joining the Sumi tribals of Nagaland in a war dance during the Hornbill Festival, he's building bonds and understanding the deep connections between the flavours and fervour of the various momentous occasions that make our country special. As the peripatetic presenter of National Geographic India's brand new series *India's Mega Festivals*, Mehigan brings his incredible energy and irascible wit to the screen in an explosion of colour and culture.

The first season, which premiered on September 6, features six festivals—Onam, Holi, Hornbill, Eid, Durga Puja and Ganesh Chaturthi—while he and the team are already working on season two. Criss-crossing the country, spending at least a week per episode, often shooting round the clock, they have managed to pack the fast-paced series with interviews, insights, and Mehigan's entertaining shenanigans.

What Mehigan has really learnt to appreciate while travelling so widely with National Geographic India is the diversity of the country. "You can say the word, but it doesn't really mean anything until you've experienced it. And now I find myself correcting Indian friends that haven't been to Nagaland, or Ladakh or Tamil Nadu or those who know only one recipe for *medu vada* while I know 10!" he chuckles.

That's a long way from his early encounters with what was considered Indian cuisine while he was growing up in the UK. "From the ever-popular chicken tikka masala to dal makhani and rogan josh and butter chicken, all of those things were my first experiences," he says. Several visits to India followed in the past 12 years. "Since then, I prefer parantha, or idiyappam, or Naga pork, because it's so much more than that menu of 12 dishes that most people probably think Indian food's all about."

Some of the experiences while filming the show were truly transformative, says Mehigan, describing the Onam Sadhya at the Vamana Moorthy Temple at Thrikkakkara in Kerala served to over 30,000 people. "Not only seeing the food being prepared and served, but the feeling and the sense of community and love and devotion and charity, all of these things make Sadhya for me now a different thing," he explains.



THE FIRST season of India's Mega Festivals includes Onam, Holi, Hornbill, Eid, Durga Puja and Ganesh Chaturthi

His tastes have changed, Mehigan admits. In his own home, he now uses a wet grinder, his last meal was *dal-chawal*, and his 22-year-old daughter Jenna loves spices just as much as he does. The Indian grocer in the neighbourhood knows him well and anticipates his kitchen adventures.

This is what he hopes *India's Mega Festivals* will do for others, especially if it's picked up by National Geographic all over the world. "I think then the broad brushstroke that everybody slaps across Indian food will start to change. When people will go, 'Where are you from?' And you say, 'Kerala' and they go 'Ah, the home of the'...even if it's 'the coconut', it's enough." ■

Priya Pathiyan